

A SURVEY REPORT ON

**EMERGING TRENDS IN LOW-CODE APPLICATION
DEVELOPMENT: A STUDY OF ZOHOCREATOR**

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Abstract

Low-code app development used to be a small shortcut. Now it is a big part of how companies build software. This report looks at the new trends in low-code tools in 2026. It focuses mainly on Zoho Creator, one of the top platforms in this area. The report explains how AI, built-in analytics, smart automation, multiple test environments, and better control features are now part of low-code tools. These changes affect who builds apps and how fast apps go live. The report also compares Zoho Creator with other platforms, looks at its good points and its limits, and talks about where low-code tools are headed next. The goal is to give a clear and simple picture of where Zoho Creator stands today.

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1. Introduction

For a long time, building software has been slow. Companies do not have enough developers, release cycles take too long, and business teams often need apps faster than the IT team can deliver them. Low-code platforms try to fix this problem. Instead of writing a lot of code by hand, developers use visual tools like drag-and-drop builders. This lets both trained developers and normal business users, often called “citizen developers,” build working apps much faster than before.

Experts say this market will keep growing fast. Gartner, a well-known research firm, expects that most new business apps will use low-code tools soon. It also expects that most people using these tools will not be from the IT department at all. This is changing not just how apps are built, but who builds them. Professional developers are spending less time writing everyday code and more time guiding the overall design, security, and rules of a system.

Zoho Creator is one of the most well-known platforms in this field. It is an AI-powered low-code platform. This means people with little or no coding skill can still build web and mobile business apps using its simple drag-and-drop tools. For more advanced needs, users can also write their own scripts. This report looks at the trends changing low-code development in general, and shows how Zoho Creator follows, and sometimes leads, these trends.

1.1 Objectives of the Survey

- To explain what low-code application development means today.
- To find the new trends shaping the low-code market in 2026.
- To study Zoho Creator's design, features, and recent updates in detail.
- To compare Zoho Creator with other popular low-code platforms.
- To look at the benefits, limits, and control-related challenges of using low-code tools.
- To describe where low-code platforms are likely headed in the future.

2. Overview of Low-Code Development and Zoho Creator

2.1 What is Low-Code Development?

Low-code development is a way of building software that needs very little hand-written code. Instead, it uses visual design tools, ready-made parts, templates, and simple settings to build the app's logic. This is different from no-code platforms, which do not allow any coding at all. Low-code platforms still let developers write some custom code when they need extra features that the visual tools cannot provide.

2.2 Zoho Creator at a Glance

Zoho Creator is a cloud-based low-code platform made by Zoho Corporation. It is built for creating custom web and mobile business apps. It is used by both professional developers and everyday business users in fields like finance, healthcare, education, manufacturing, retail, and logistics. An app built once on Zoho Creator can run on desktops, tablets, and both iOS and Android phones without extra work.

Its main features include a drag-and-drop form and page builder, automatic workflows, a scripting language called Deluge for custom logic, ready-made templates for different industries, and easy connections to other Zoho apps and outside tools. The platform hides most of the technical complexity of building an app. This lets teams focus on the business need and the user experience instead of worrying about the technical setup underneath.

2.3 Market Position

Zoho Creator is regularly ranked as one of the top platforms in the low-code space. Reviewers like its easy-to-use design, strong workflow automation, support for many devices, and good data handling. It also has a simple per-user pricing plan with a free starting tier, which makes it affordable for small and mid-sized businesses as well as large companies.

3. Emerging Trends in Low-Code Application Development

In 2026, the low-code market is no longer just about simple drag-and-drop tools. It is now more about how deeply platforms use artificial intelligence, control tools, and built-in analytics. The trends below, based on recent industry news and platform updates, show where this field is heading.

3.1 AI-Native Development Environments

Most low-code platforms now come with a built-in AI helper. A user can simply type what they want in plain language, and the AI creates a working form, workflow, or report. This is a shift from pure drag-and-drop building to a ‘tell the AI what you want’ style of building. Zoho Creator follows this trend with AI-assisted features that cut down the manual setup work needed to build new parts of an app.

3.2 Agentic Automation

One big trend is the growth of AI “agents” built directly into business apps. These agents can complete multi-step tasks on their own, not just answer a single question. Analysts expect these AI agent features to appear in a large share of business software over the next few years. But many early AI agent projects are also expected to fail if they are not properly managed and

supervised. Zoho's larger platform plan, known internally as “AppOS,” treats tools like Zoho Creator and Zoho Flow as building blocks that AI agents can use and control under business guidance.

3.3 Embedded Business Intelligence and Analytics

Instead of needing a separate analytics tool, low-code platforms are now building analytics directly into the app itself. Zoho Creator now supports features like predictive analytics, data alerts, what-if analysis, mixing data from different sources, and asking questions in plain language to get insights. Teams can now understand their data without exporting it to another tool.

3.4 Multi-Environment Deployment and DevOps Maturity

As low-code apps become more important to daily business, platforms are adopting practices once used only in traditional software development. Zoho Creator now lets developers set up separate spaces for development, testing, and live use. Changes can be moved between these spaces with a single click. This makes it safer to test new features without breaking the app that people are already using.

3.5 Centralized Governance and Security

As more people outside the IT department start building apps, having proper control and oversight has become very important. Features like detailed access controls, activity logs, backup and recovery options, and central dashboards for managing users and billing are now expected as standard. This shows a wider pattern in the industry: IT teams still oversee standards, security, and integration, even while regular business users build the apps themselves.

3.6 Integrated Collaboration Tooling

Since new, non-technical builders often get stuck on small problems, platforms are now adding communication tools right inside the app-building screen. These include chat, file sharing, screen sharing, and audio or video calls. This way, builders can get help quickly without having to leave the platform.

3.7 Industry-Specific Templates and Vertical Solutions

Instead of being just a general app-building tool, platforms now offer ready-made apps built for specific industries. For example, Zoho Creator has a gallery of dozens of ready-made apps for tasks like field service management, expense and purchase tracking, customer self-service portals, compliance tracking, and HR management. This means businesses can start using these apps quickly instead of building everything from scratch.

3.8 Blurring of Developer and Business-User Roles

As AI takes over more of the repetitive coding work, professional developers are expected to spend less time on routine code and more time on system design, business knowledge, and creative problem-solving. At the same time, regular business users are building more apps on their own. Industry experts say this does not mean developers are being replaced. Instead, their role is shifting closer to solving real business problems for customers.

4. Comparative Analysis with Other Low-Code Platforms

Zoho Creator competes with many other low-code platforms, and each one has its own strong point. The table below shows how Zoho Creator compares with a few other popular platforms in 2026.

Platform	Primary Strength	AI Capability	Best Fit
Zoho Creator	Deep Zoho-suite integration, embedded BI	AI-assisted app & workflow generation	SMBs to mid-market, cross-department apps
OutSystems	Enterprise-grade scalability and security	AI-assisted code generation, agent workflows	Large enterprise, mission-critical systems
Mendix	Multi-experience app support across devices	AI copilot for modeling and testing	Complex multi-channel enterprise apps
Microsoft Power Apps	Deep Microsoft 365 / Azure integration	Copilot Studio for agent building	Organizations standardized on Microsoft stack
Retool	Fast internal tool building on live databases	AI-assisted UI and query generation	Internal tools connected to existing data sources

The main thing that sets Zoho Creator apart is that it is part of the larger Zoho One family of apps. This means apps built on Creator can easily work together with Zoho CRM, Zoho Books, Zoho Flow, and many other Zoho apps, without needing extra setup work. This makes it a great choice for companies that already use Zoho products. Platforms like OutSystems and Mendix, on the other hand, are usually chosen by large companies that need very large, high-security systems.

5. Representative Use Cases

Because Zoho Creator is so flexible, it is used across many different business areas. The examples below show where the platform makes the biggest difference.

5.1 Field Service Management

Companies use Zoho Creator to track which technician is assigned to which job, collect customer feedback on-site, and update job status in real time. This works even offline, and the mobile app can also tag the technician's location.

5.2 Expense and Procurement Tracking

Approval steps and budget checks are automated from start to finish. This reduces manual checking of numbers and makes it easier for finance teams to prepare for audits.

5.3 Customer Self-Service Portals

Companies can build secure, branded portals where clients can check reports, raise service requests, or track project status by themselves. The IT team does not need to get involved every time a new client joins.

5.4 Regulatory Compliance Tracking

Industries with strict rules, like pharmaceuticals and finance, use custom Zoho Creator apps to record and constantly check compliance data against company rules and outside regulations.

5.5 HR and Employee Engagement

New employee onboarding, leave requests, and performance reviews are all managed in one single app. This replaces the mess of scattered spreadsheets and long email chains.

6. Benefits and Challenges of Low-Code Adoption

6.1 Benefits

- App building time is usually cut by half or more compared to writing everything in code by hand.
- Less need for hard-to-find developers, which helps with developer shortages and long IT waiting lists.
- Business teams and IT teams can work together faster because they use the same visual models.
- One app build works on both web and mobile, so there is no need to build separately for each platform.

- Built-in connections to existing business tools mean less custom integration work is needed.

6.2 Challenges and Risks

- Getting stuck with one vendor, since it can be hard to move an app off a closed, private platform.
- Limited customization for very specialized needs or tasks that need top performance.
- Security and control risks when regular business users build apps without any IT oversight (sometimes called “shadow IT”).
- Risk of trusting AI-generated logic too much without proper testing, especially for AI agent features.
- Possible early job loss in routine, repetitive programming roles.

7. Future Scope

Industry experts expect low-code tools to keep moving from a minor part of company IT to a central part of it. Gartner predicts that most important business apps will depend on low-code platforms within the next few years. This means low-code is becoming standard practice, not just a quick shortcut.

For Zoho Creator, likely next steps include stronger AI agent features as part of its AppOS plan, better control and audit checks around AI features to avoid the high failure rate seen in poorly managed AI agent projects, and a smarter built-in analytics engine that can find insights more on its own. Across the whole industry, the difference between ‘low-code’ and ‘AI-based development’ is expected to shrink further. Building apps by simply describing them to an AI is likely to become the normal starting point, not a special feature.

8. Conclusion

Low-code app development has grown from a simple shortcut for small internal tools into a major part of how companies build software. The combination of AI, built-in analytics, smart automation, and strong governance tools is changing what these platforms can do and who can use them. Zoho Creator is a good example of this change. It combines an easy-to-use visual builder with more advanced AI, analytics, and control features, while staying closely connected to a wider family of business apps. As companies keep facing developer shortages and long IT to-do lists, platforms like Zoho Creator are set to play an even bigger role in how businesses build and run important software.

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